

Sanghoon Kim-Leffingwell

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ACADEMIC POSITIONS

University of North Texas

Department of Political Science
Assistant Professor

2024 – present

Johns Hopkins University

Data Analytics and Policy Program
Sr. Lecturer and Assistant Director
Sr. Lecturer and Program Coordinator
SNF Agora Institute
Faculty Affiliate

2023 – 2024

2022 – 2023

2023 – 2024

EDUCATION

University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign

Ph.D. Political Science

2022

Korea University

M.A. Political Science

2016

B.A. Political Science; Economics

2011

RESEARCH INTERESTS

- Comparative politics: authoritarian legacies, authoritarian nostalgia, democratic development, Asian Politics
- International relations: IR and domestic politics, international political economy
- Political methodology: experimental methods, text analysis, image-as-data, mixed-methods approach

BOOK PROJECT

The Past that Binds: Authoritarian Nostalgia, Nationalist Polarization, and Voter Behavior

- Under review at Cambridge University Press
- Book workshops held in April, May 2025
- Winner of the Kathleen L. Burkholder Prize for the Best Dissertation, Department of Political Science, University of Illinois.

PEER-REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS

“Engaged but Targeted? How Immigrants Vote Against Anti-Immigrant Agendas in Europe.” with Younghyun Lee. 2026. *Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies*. 52(13): 3323-3347.¹

“Violence and Bias: The Long-term Effects of Ethnic Discrimination on Anti-China Protest in Indonesia.” with Yujeong Yang. 2026. *Comparative Politics*. 58(3): 313-338.

“Authoritarian Nostalgia, Group Sentiment, and Voter Behavior: Evidence from East Asia.” 2025. *Political Behavior*. 47(3): 1231-1252.

“How Loud Does the Watchdog Bark? A Reconsideration of Local Journalism, News Non-profits, and Political Corruption.” with Nikki Usher. 2024. *International Journal of Press/Politics*. 29(4): 960-982.

“Mnemonic Politics among Philippine Voters: A Social Media Measurement Approach.” with Emily Sallenback. 2024. *Democratization*. 31(8): 1622-1644.*

“Money Backfires: How Chinese Investment Fuels Anti-China Protests Abroad.” with Yujeong Yang, Do Young Gong, and Shuyuan Shen. 2024. *World Development*. 178: 106566.*

¹Papers with undergraduate/graduate students.

- “Killing Protests with Kindness: Anti-China Protests and China’s Public Diplomacy.” with Yujeong Yang, Do Young Gong, and Shuyuan Shen. 2023. *International Studies Quarterly*. 67(4): squad087.*
- “Authoritarian Legacies and Partisan Bias in Corruption Voting: Evidence from South Korea.” 2023. *Journal of East Asian Studies*. 23(2): 241-262.
- “Personality Traits, Democratic Support, and Authoritarian Nostalgia.” 2023. *Social Science Quarterly*. 104(5): 619-635.
- “Alternative Legacies of Authoritarianism: Pro-dictator Bias in Ideology.” 2023. *Party Politics*. 29(3): 580-586.

BOOK CHAPTERS

- “Authoritarian Nostalgia.” (forthcoming) In *Encyclopedia of Authoritarianism*, Thomas Ambrosio and Stephen Hall (eds.). Edward Elgar Publishing.
- “Legacies of Authoritarianism.” with Madline Silver. (forthcoming) In *Handbook of Political Socialization*, Jill S. Greenlee and Zoe M. Oxley (eds.). De Gruyter.¹

UNDER REVIEW

- “Too Young to be Nostalgic?: Young Voters and the Rise in Authoritarian Nostalgia.”

RESEARCH IN PROGRESS

- “Pixelated Authoritarian Nostalgia: An Image-as-data Approach to Nostalgic Images of Former Dictators in the Media.” with Hyein Ko; Presented at MPSA 2025, IPSA 2025, and APSA 2025)
- “Synthetic Authoritarian Nostalgia: Media Depiction of Authoritarian Legacies in South Korea.” with Hyein Ko.
- “Authoritarian Nostalgia and Partisan Attachment.” with Sunkyoung Park.
- “Last Ones Standing: Local Politics and Authoritarian Symbol Removal in Taiwan.” With Risa Kitagawa and Yu-hsien Sung.
- “Right in the Past, Left in the Present?: Ideological Orientation and Political Nostalgia.”
- “Learning to Love Dictators: The Effect of Museums Dedicated to Former Dictatorial Rulers.” with Matt Winters.

GRANTS AND AWARDS

Research related

- 2026-2027 U.S.–Korea NextGen Scholars Program, Center for Strategic and International Studies (CSIS).
- Junior Faculty Summer Research Support Award, University of North Texas, 2025.
- Faculty Grant Award, SNF Agora Institute, Johns Hopkins University, 2023.
- Doctoral Fellowship, Chiang Ching-kuo Foundation for International Scholarly Exchange, 2021.
- Ferber & Sudman Dissertation Awards for Survey Research, University of Illinois, 2020.
- Nelle M. Signor Graduate Scholarship in International Relations, University of Illinois, 2020.
- CEAPS Graduate Student Dissertation Travel Grant, Center for East Asian and Pacific Studies, University of Illinois, 2020.
- Taiwan Fellowship, Ministry of Foreign Affairs, Republic of China, 2020.
- Graduate College Dissertation Travel Grant, University of Illinois, 2019.
- William A. Schroeder and Paul W. Schroeder Summer Fellowship, the Cline Center for Advanced Social Research, University of Illinois, 2018.
- Rita and Leonard Ogren Award for Academic Excellence, Department of Political Science, University of Illinois, 2018.
- National Humanities and Social Sciences Graduate Research Scholarship, Korea Student Aid Foundation, 2011-2012
- Undergraduate Honors Scholarship, Korea University, 2007.

Teaching related

- Excellence in Teaching Award, Center for Advanced Governmental Studies, Johns Hopkins University, 2023.
- A. Belden Fields Award for Graduate Student Teaching as a TA, Department of Political Science, University of Illinois, 2019.

¹Papers with undergraduate/graduate students.

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

- Midwest Political Science Association. 2018-2019, 2021-2026.
- International Studies Association. 2026.
- American Political Science Association. 2021-2025.
- International Political Science Association. 2025.
- Association for Asian Studies. 2025.
- Southwest Workshop on Mixed-Methods Research (SWMMR). 2024.
- American Sociology Association. 2023.
- Midwest Conference on Asian Affairs. 2021, 2023.
- Association for Asian Studies, AAS-in-Asia. 2023.
- Society of Political Methodology (PolMeth). 2022.
- International Convention of Asian Scholars. 2021.

EXTERNAL PRESENTATIONS

- Authoritarian Nostalgia in East & Southeast Asia Conference. City University of Hong Kong. June 2026.
- Social Science Korea Invited Talk. Hankuk University of Foreign Studies, Seoul. June 2026.
- Perspectives on Contemporary Korea Conference. Nam Center for Korean Studies, University of Michigan, Ann Arbor. December 2025.
- The 12th International Conference of NextGen Korean Studies Scholars. Nam Center for Korean Studies, University of Michigan, Ann Arbor. May 2025.
- Asian Summer School on Political Parties and Democracy Program. National Chengchi University. Taipei, Taiwan. May 2024.
- Taiwan Democracy Quarterly-Taiwan Journal of Democracy Conference on “A Season of Elections, New (or renewed) Leadership, and Policy Impacts.” University of Nevada, Las Vegas. April 2024.
- Conference on Judicial Politics and Human Rights: Taiwan in Comparative Perspective. University of South Carolina. December 2023.
- Taiwan in Transition Conference. University of Nottingham, UK, June 2023.
- Frontiers in Empirical Research on East Asia. New York University. May 2023.
- Institute for Korean Studies Annual Research Symposium. University of Missouri. April 2023.
- Taiwan and Asian Program Conference. University of South Carolina (virtual). 2021.

OTHER RESEARCH EXPERIENCES

Fieldwork

- **South Korea.** Data collection and online surveys. January-March 2020; June-July 2023; May-July 2025.
- **Taiwan.** Data collection, focus groups, elite interviews, and online surveys. January-March 2020; June-July 2023.
- **Philippines.** Interviews and data collection. May 2026.
- **Indonesia.** Elite interviews and survey monitoring. November 2019; August 2022.

Research Assistant

- Research Assistant, Nikki Usher, College of Media, University of Illinois, 2019-2021.
 - Empirical research in *News for the Rich, White, and Blue* (Columbia University Press, 2021).
- Research Assistant, Professor Matthew Winters, Department of Political Science, University of Illinois, 2021.
 - Analyses on Multilevel Modeling, Item Response Theory
- Research Assistant, Professor Avital Livny, Department of Political Science, University of Illinois, 2019-2020.
 - NSF-awarded project, “Improving and Integrating Global Diversity Estimates.” (NSF #1824005)
- Research Assistant, Professor Hyung-min Joo, Korea University, Seoul, Korea, 2016.
- Research Assistant, East Asia Institute, Seoul, Korea, 2015.
- Brain Korea 21 Research Assistant, Korea University, Seoul, Korea, 2013.

TEACHING INTERESTS

Comparative politics, political research methods, Asian politics, political behavior, democracy and autocracy

TEACHING EXPERIENCES

University of North Texas

2024 – present

PSCI6000 Computational Social Science, Fall 2026.
 PSCI2305 US Political Behavior and Policy, Summer, Fall 2026.
 PSCI3300 Political Science Research Methods, Fall 2025, Spring 2026.
 PSCI3600 Governments and Politics around the World, Spring 2026.
 PSCI6625 Democracy and Democratization, Fall 2025.
 PSCI4300/5300 Visualizing Political Data, Spring 2025.
 PSCI4661 Politics of Autocracy, Fall 2024.

Johns Hopkins University 2022 – 2024

AS470.667 Machine Learning Methods and Applications, Fall 2023.
 AS470.681 Probability and Statistics, Summer, Fall 2022, Summer, Fall 2023.
 AS470.708 Unleashing Open Data with Python, Summer 2023.
 AS470.854 Fundamentals of Quantitative Methods, Spring 2023.
 AS470.669 Mathematics for Data Scientists, Fall 2022, Spring 2023.
 AS470.768 Programming and Data Management, Summer 2022.

University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign 2019 – 2022

PS230 Introduction to Political Research, Spring 2021, Spring 2022[†].
 PS241 Comparative Politics in Developing Nations (Online), Winter 2019-2020, Spring 2020.
 GLBL296 Global Politics of Intellectual Property Protection, Spring 2019.
 PS100 Introduction to Political Science (Online), Spring 2019.

Graduate Teaching Assistant, University of Illinois 2016 – 2021

PS231 Strategic Models, Fall 2020[†], Fall 2021[†].
 PS241 Comparative Politics in Developing Nations, Spring 2018*, Fall 2018*.
 PS224 Politics of the National Parks, Summer 2017.
 PS220 Introduction to Public Policy, Fall 2017.
 PS321 Principles of Public Policy, Spring 2017.
 PS322 Law and Public Policy, Fall 2016.

* Ranked as “Outstanding” in the top 10 percent campuswide.

[†] Ranked as “Excellent” with students evaluation greater than 4.3/5.0.

Graduate Teaching Assistant, Inter-university Consortium for Political and Social Research (ICPSR),
 University of Michigan 2021

Causal Inference for the Social Sciences, Summer 2021.

Graduate Mentor, University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign 2021 – 2022

Undergraduate Research Apprenticeship Program.

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE

Reviewer

Journals: *American Political Science Review*; *Asian Survey*; *Comparative Political Studies*; *Comparative Politics*; *Democratization*; *East European Politics*; *Electoral Studies*; *Japanese Journal of Political Science*; *Journal of Elections, Public Opinion, and Parties*; *Journal of Politics*; *Journal of Social and Political Psychology*; *Pacific Affairs*; *Party Politics*; *Political Behavior*; *Political Psychology*; *Political Research Quarterly*; *Political Science Research and Methods*; *Research & Politics*; *Taiwan Politics*; *World Development*.

Book publishers: *Lynne Rienner Publishers*.

Institutions: *APSA Centennial Center Research Grants*; *National Science Foundation*; *National Science Center, Poland*

Country Expert for South Korea: Varieties of Democracy Project (V-Dem).

Asian Politics Section Chair, 2027 Annual Midwest Political Science Association.

Organizer: Complete Panel on Authoritarian Legacies and Political Behavior, the 2021 annual MPSA

Conference, Chicago, IL (Participants: Kharis Templeman, Joseph Wong, Monika Prusik, Nate Grubman, Myunghee Lee); East Asian Politics Workshop, University of Illinois, 2021; Comparative Politics Graduate Workshop, University of Illinois, 2018-2021.

PROGRAMMING

R, RMarkdown, Python, L^AT_EX, Basic HTML language
Microsoft Office, Adobe Acrobat, Adobe Photoshop, Adobe InDesign

LANGUAGE

Korean (native), English (proficient), Chinese (intermediate), Japanese (basic)

OTHER EXPERIENCE

Treasurer, Political Science Graduate Student Association, University of Illinois, 2020-2021.
Chair, Methods Sequence Committee, Political Science Graduate Student Association, University of Illinois, Fall, 2019.
Graduate Assistant, Center for East Asian and Pacific Studies, University of Illinois, 2019.
Math Camp Committee, Political Science Graduate Student Association, University of Illinois, 2018-2021.
Subject-Matter Expert, ASEAN Cyber University Secretariat, Seoul, South Korea, 2015-2016.
Editorial Assistant, Peace Studies Journal, Korea University, 2012-2013.
Graduate Assistant, Center for Teaching and Learning, Korea University, 2012-2013.
Graduate Assistant, Department of Political Science, Korea University, 2011-2012.

Last updated: August 24, 2026